

What is AEO? Answer engine optimization explained for a local business

Dillon Mohr · Momentum Digital

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What is AEO? Answer engine optimization, explained for a local business

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

AEO, answer engine optimization, is the work of getting your business named in the answer when someone asks an AI a question. Not ranked on a page of links. Named, in the sentence, as a source. For a local service business it means your service page, your Google listing and your reviews are clear enough for a machine to cite.

That's the whole definition. The rest of this post is what it means for an HVAC shop, a landscaper, a bridal boutique or a law office, and what to do first.

Why is everyone suddenly asking what AEO means?

Because the word showed up in a sales pitch and nobody defined it plainly.

Search interest tells the story. "What is aeo" gets about 4,400 searches per month in the US. Two years ago it was 140. That's a 47x climb in 24 months. The spelled-out cousin, "generative engine optimization", is going the other way in the US, down from 6,600 a month to 2,900. People are using the short word. So I'll use the short word.

The pages that answer it today are written for marketers. The top result is an AI-visibility software vendor. Then HubSpot. Salesforce is further down. Good pages. None of them written for someone who fixes furnaces and wants to know whether to spend money on this.

What is the difference between SEO, AEO and GEO?

Same raw materials, different finish line.

	SEO	AEO	GEO
Goal	Rank on the results page	Be named in the answer	Be used as a source by generative AI
Where you show up	A blue link	A sentence with a citation	ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews
What it rewards	Authority, relevance, links	Direct answers to specific questions	Clear, quotable, verifiable pages
How you measure it	Position and clicks	Cited or not, per engine, per question	Same, plus which page got used

In practice AEO and GEO are the same work. AEO is the word buyers use. GEO is the word tool vendors use. I'll say AEO and mean both.

SEO isn't dead and this isn't a replacement for it. An AI engine cites pages it can find and trust, and the way it finds and trusts them looks a lot like the way Google always has. If your site can't be crawled, none of this applies to you yet.

Does a local business actually need AEO, or is it a marketing word?

It's a marketing word, and you still need the work under it.

Here's the honest version. The things that make a page citable are things a good local site should have had anyway. A service page that says what you do, where, for whom, and answers the questions people ask before they call. A Google Business Profile with the right categories and hours. Reviews that mention the service by name. An author. A date.

What's new is the precision. A search engine forgives a vague page because it ranks it against other vague pages. An answer engine doesn't rank. It picks one or three sources and quotes them. Vague pages don't get quoted.

So the question isn't "do I need AEO". It's "is my service page specific enough to be quoted". Most aren't. Ours weren't either, which I'll get to.

What do AI engines actually cite?

I can only show you what I measured. In Google's AI Overviews, on the topic of answer engine optimization itself, the twenty most-cited sources are led by YouTube at 28.3% of citations and Reddit at 13.9%. Then Semrush, then Google's own developer documentation. Reddit and Quora together hold about 17%. One agency appears in the top twenty. One.

That's a topic where every agency in the country is trying to be cited. The engines are citing videos, forum threads and Google's own docs instead.

Our own footprint is worth putting on the record. In a sampled window of AI Overview answers running from August 2025 to August 2026, needmomentum.com was cited 81 times. In a set of six agencies including us, we ranked fifth. The pages that got cited were a how-to on verifying a Google Business Profile by postcard, our Google Ads page, and a DIY web design page. Not one was about AI.

Two lessons from that. Specific, procedural pages get cited. And an agency selling AEO should be able to show you its own number before it asks for yours.

Where do I start? The 20-question baseline

Don't buy anything yet. Do this first. It takes an afternoon.

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1. Write down 20 questions your buyers ask before they call you. Real ones. "Does a heat pump work in a Philadelphia winter." "How much does a paver patio cost per square foot." "Do I need a permit to replace a fence." Pull them from your phone log, your inbox and your best salesperson.
 2. Ask each question in two engines. Google with AI Overviews on, and ChatGPT or Perplexity. Same wording both places.
 3. For each answer, record four things: the engine, the exact prompt, the date, and every source it cited. A spreadsheet is fine.
 4. Count how many times you appear. Count who appears instead.

That's your baseline. It's not a rank. It's a dated list of observations you can repeat next month and compare. Anyone who reports AEO results to you without the engine, the prompt, the date and the source on every line is giving you a feeling, not a measurement.

If you appear zero times, that's normal. Most local businesses do. The list of who appears instead is your homework. Usually it's a directory, a manufacturer, a Reddit thread and one competitor with a very specific page.

FAQ

Is AEO the same as GEO? For a local business, yes. AEO is the term buyers search for and GEO is the term software vendors use. The work underneath, making pages clear enough for an AI to cite, is the same.

Can I pay to be in an AI answer? Not the organic answer. Some engines now sell labeled ad placements, and those are ads. The citations inside the answer itself are earned, and no vendor can guarantee them.

How long before I see anything? I don't have a number I'd publish. Engines change monthly and results vary by engine and by question. What you can control is the baseline, dated, and the re-measurement 30 days later.

The next step

If you want a second pair of eyes before you do the baseline yourself, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations about your business with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com and tell me your top service and your city.

Momentum built the machine. Now we build yours.